Fire Risk Assessment

Churches are required to undertake a Fire Risk Assessment in accordance with the Regulatory Reform (Fire Safety) Order 2005. In Scotland, fire safety duties are contained in part 3 of The Fire (Scotland) Act 2005, as amended and The Fire Safety (Scotland) Regulations 2006.

Ecclesiastical has developed this Fire Risk Assessment based on our own expertise. This assessment can only be used by churches whose normal activities are limited to what might be expected in a church building such as services and occasional public events such as concerts.

A fire risk assessment is a legal document. If using this template, you should check that it matches your specific circumstance exactly. If it doesn't, you should amend it to do so.

Churches with a wider range of activities such as night shelters, lettings and nurseries should consider appointing an accredited fire risk assessor to support them in completing their Fire Risk Assessment. Example accredited certification bodies include the Institute of Fire Prevention Officers (IFPO), Institute of Fire Safety Managers (IFSM) and Institution of Fire Engineers (IFE). It is important any assessor appointed has knowledge in completing fire risk assessment in heritage and faith buildings.

How to use this Fire Risk Assessment

The assessment has the following sections which you will need to read and then complete:

Part 1 – Information About Our Church

Part 1 of the assessment is about collecting together all the information you need about your church so that you can perform the Fire Risk Assessment. It is broken down into various sections which are summarised below.

A Our Church Details
Basic information about our church location and the person responsible for the Fire Risk Assessment.

B Parochial Church Council Declaration
A declaration about the awareness and understanding of the Parochial Church Council (PCC) or other church management committee of the requirements of the Order to be signed by the appropriate person.

Risk Advice Line

Should you have any additional questions on this topic or other risk-related matters, as a valued Ecclesiastical customer you can contact us through our Risk Advice Line on **0345 600 7531** (Monday to Friday 9am – 5pm, excluding bank holidays) and one of our in-house risk professionals will be able to assist.

Alternatively, you can email us at

risk.advice@ecclesiastical.com

and one of our experts will call you back within 24 hours.

C General Information About Our Church
Description of the church building and how it is used.

D Potential Fire Hazards At Our Church
Details of fire hazards, sources of ignition and their elimination or control.

E Our Fire Protection Arrangements
Details of the current arrangements we have in place for fire protection.

F Our Fire Detection, Warning And Extinguisher Equipment
Details of the equipment we have in place and its testing and maintenance.

G Our Fire Safety Management
Information about our plans should a fire occur.

Part 2 – Our Fire Risk Assessment
Part 2 of the assessment is about the fire risks at our church and how we will go about fulfilling our obligations under the order.

Part 3 – Our Arrangements for Fire Safety At Our Church
Part 3 of the assessment details the measures we have taken to offset the risk of fire at our church.

Part 4 – Our Action Plan To Reduce Fire Risk At Our Church
Part 4 details any gaps in our fire protection arrangements and outlines what we are going to do to address them.

Appendix 1
Examples to help you complete Part 2 – Our Fire Risk Assessment.

Appendix 2
Examples to help you complete Part 3 – Our Arrangements For Fire Safety At Our Church.

Appendix 3 Fire Action Notice
A specimen notice that needs to be placed near all exit doors and in separate areas such as vestries, which you will need to complete for your church.

Part 1 – Information About Our church

A.Our Church Details

Name of church:

Address:

Responsible person:
Employer or other persons having control of the relevant premises e.g. PCC.

In the diocese of:

B.Parochial Church Council Declaration

As a church, we understand that we are required to undertake a Fire Risk Assessment in accordance with the Regulatory Reform (Fire Safety) Order 2005 (in Scotland, fire safety duties are contained in part 3 of The Fire Scotland Act 2005, as amended and The Fire Safety Scotland Regulations 2006) even if we have no employees.

We note that we are required to take such general fire precautions as will ensure, so far as is reasonably practicable, the safety of employees, if we have any, and to take such general fire precautions as may reasonably be required in the circumstances to ensure that the premises are safe for all other visitors to the church including volunteers, members of the congregation, and contractors. Our Fire Risk Assessment and arrangements are therefore directed to the safety of people rather than the protection of the building itself.

We understand the PCC is the responsible person, and we will appoint one or more competent persons as appropriate to assist us in undertaking the preventative and protective measures.

We understand it is the responsibility of the **Responsible Person(s)** to fully record the following information in the fire
risk assessment:- l All findings from their fire risk assessment regardless of the size or purpose of the premises in full. l Fire Safety Arrangements that show how you manage fire safety in the building. These can be anything from procedures you need to have written down to polices you have in place. l Details of the appointed Fire Risk Assessor who undertakes or reviews any or all of the fire risk assessment.

In carrying out our Fire Risk Assessment, we have followed the Government guidance published by the Department for Communities and Local Government (for Scotland – Scottish Government's Police and Community Safety Directorate, HM Fire Service Inspectorate for Scotland, the Scottish Building Standards Agency and the Health and Safety Executive) and have noted from this document that the action we take should be common sense and in the main, not expensive. We have also noted Appendix C of the guidance for Fire safety risk assessment: small and medium places of assembly which refers to listed and historic buildings and note that we will need to endeavour to strike a balance between ensuring sufficient fire safety measures are in place for the safety of people, yet avoid extensive alterations and helping to maintain the character of the building.

Signed on behalf of the PCC:

Persons appointed to assist the PCC in undertaking fire preventative and protective measures:

Date fire risk assessment was completed:

Suggested review date:

(The risk assessment needs to be reviewed regularly to keep it up to date, particularly where there is reason to suspect that it is no longer valid, or there has been a significant change in the matters to which it relates.)

You can see the full documentation referred to above at the links below: Regulatory Reform (Fire Safety) Order 2005:
www.legislation.gov.uk/uksi/2005/1541/contents/made

Government Guidance including a fire risk assessment form is available from:
www.communities.gov.uk/fire/firesafety/firesafetylaw/aboutguides/

A document that may also be of assistance is the Fire Safety Risk Assessment Small and Medium Places of Assembly:
www.gov.uk/government/collections/fire-safety-legislation-guidance-for-those-with-legal-duties

For Scotland, a document that may be of assistance is Practical Fire Safety Guidance for Places of Entertainment and Assembly:
www.firesafetyfirst.co.uk/freedownloadspublications.html

C.General Information About Our Church

THE BUILDING:

Number of floors: Floor area (approximate overall size in square metres):

(You will need to measure the building to calculate things like the number of fire extinguishers required and travel distances. See also 'Plan' below.)

Building description:

(Describe what the building comprises noting if there is one main undivided area and then separate parts which can be closed off from the main area which could prevent the spread of a fire, e.g. The main undivided area of the church comprises a lofty nave and chancel with north and south aisles and organ chamber. There are north and south porches and a vestry all of which can be closed off from the main part of the church by substantial oak doors. There is a tower at the west end of the church which is completely separated from the rest of the church and can only be accessed from an external door.)

Basic construction details:

(For example, The church is built of stone/brick with a slate/tile roof on a timber frame. The floor is of solid construction covered with tiles.)

Use of the church:

Note the use of the building and how often it is occupied, e.g. The church is used for services twice on a Sunday but otherwise the use is very limited. There is the occasional concert. You should draw a plan of the church which can be used during the risk assessment process and then as a part of your fire safety arrangements documentation. This should be roughly to scale and should identify by name the main parts of the church and note all doors both internal, which separate different parts of the church, and external, which provide means of escape.
The plan can be used to note the location of fire extinguishers and other relevant information.

You can use a tape measure or rule to measure the building but an easy way is to pace along the outside walls and note down the distances. A good pace is about 1 metre. There is a blank page at the back of this document for you to draw a plan of your church.

PEOPLE AT RISK:

Occupants: Approximate average number attending a normal service:

Approximate maximum number attending special services and events such as weddings and at Christmas:

Approximate number of employees and/or volunteers in the church at any one time:

OCCUPANTS AT SPECIAL RISK FROM FIRE:

Give details of any persons with disabilities who attend the church who would need help in evacuating the building:

Give details of any children who attend the church and whether they occupy a different part of the building during services such as a Sunday School in the vestry:

Give details of the number of persons who occupy remote parts of the building and when:

(For example, do bell ringers practice when there is no-one else in the church. Does the organist practice alone or does someone undertake maintenance in an enclosed boiler room?)

BACKGROUND INFORMATION:

Previous fire losses:

Detail any fires or related incidents that anyone can remember even if it did not result in an insurance claim:

Other relevant information:

Note any other information which could have a bearing on the risk of fire such as the nature of any nearby or adjoining premises or evidence of arson:

D. Potential Fire Hazards At Our Church

Where the answer is NO then some action may be required in order to ensure that your fire safety arrangements are satisfactory. This needs to be noted in the Action Plan at the end of the assessment. If the situation does not apply, enter N/A.

Electrical

Is the fixed electrical system inspected and tested by a competent person at least every five years? Yes

No If YES, state the name of the competent person and the date of the last inspection

Are all portable electrical appliances including those belonging to outside bodies annually Yes

No

tested? (PAT testing)

If YES, state the name of the tester and the date of the last test

Are any electrical items that fail the testing removed immediately from the church? Yes

No **Is the use of trailing leads and multi-point adaptors restricted as far as possible and** Yes

No

subject to control? ### Heating

If portable electric heaters including electric fan heaters, and radiant 'bar' type fires are used, are they included in the PAT testing programme and are they kept away from combustible materials? *(Remember to check areas that you would not normally visit such as the ringing chamber or clergy vestry.)*	Yes	No	N/A
If portable LPG (liquid petroleum gas) heaters are used, are they fixed away from combustible materials and are the arrangements for the storage and replacement of spare cylinders satisfactory?	Yes	No	N/A
If heating appliances burning coal or other solid fuel, e.g. wood pellets, are used, are arrangements in place to ensure fire cannot spread accidentally?	Yes	No	N/A
Are gas boilers subject to an annual maintenance contract with an approved Gas Safe registered contractor? If YES, state the name of the contractor and the date of the last inspection	Yes	No	N/A

Are oil-fired boilers subject to an annual maintenance contract with an approved OFTEC contractor?	Yes	No	N/A
If YES, state the name of the contractor and the date of the last inspection			
Are oil tanks suitably bunded or double skinned and fitted with a safety cut-off valve?	Yes	No	N/A
Do you ensure that all heating appliances are kept clear of combustible materials?	Yes		No